

Southwest Regional Hearing on Congressional Redistricting
Dan DeBone, Executive Director
Westmoreland County Chamber of Commerce
Thursday, August 26, 2021

On behalf of our Board of Directors and our President and CEO, Chad Amond, we want to thank Chairman Grove, Chairman Conklin, and members of the House State Government Committee for holding this important discussion on congressional redistricting. My name is Dan DeBone, Executive Director of the Westmoreland County Chamber of Commerce who represents and advocates for a healthier, more competitive business climate for over 900 members. As the largest business association in Westmoreland County – and as one of the largest Chambers in all of Southwestern Pennsylvania– we’re extremely proud that our voice continues to resonate when speaking about the interests of small and large companies across a myriad of industries, which are basically in our backyard. Policy makers and elected officials from Westmoreland County, Harrisburg, and Washington D.C. look to the Westmoreland County Chamber for an unvarnished, non-partisan assessment of what is important to our community.

Founded in 1773, Westmoreland County is the second largest county in Southwestern Pennsylvania. The county encompasses over 1,000 square miles with a population of 345,779. Adjacent counties consist of Armstrong, Indiana, Cambria, Somerset, Fayette, Washington, Allegheny and Butler County.

Westmoreland County is part of the 10-county Pittsburgh region offering its own, but very unique strengths and character for business locations. With its expansive area, access to major transportation arteries, comprehensive industrial park system and strong work ethic, Westmoreland has the business climate to assure success. That's why so many companies have grown strong within our region. Exemplified by the huge numbers of European immigrants who came to Westmoreland to work in coal mines, steel mills and glass factories during the Industrial Revolution, Westmoreland County is distinguished by a workforce that boasts traditional work ethics, values and pride. Our loyal and hard-working people are the basis to a solid manufacturing foundation that we continue to build upon. Most importantly, our region has continued to thrive

with the development of new industrial parks, steady growth of small businesses, a high tourism rate, some of the best medical facilities in the region, a number of colleges and universities, and light manufacturing.

The recent Census data in correlation with the legislative mandate will soon produce as well as dictate new congressional maps due to population shifts. The Chamber is pleased to see the stability of population in Pennsylvania and throughout neighboring counties. However, our region endured a population decline according to population estimates from the recent census. Additional estimates show Westmoreland lost 1,943 people just in 2020 through natural population changes, meaning there were more deaths than births. Westmoreland County is in the process of offsetting this change with the “Reimagining Our Westmoreland” Comprehensive Plan. This aggressive plan lays out several ideas to make the county attractive for businesses and younger generations by creating a community and environment where people want to live. The “Reimagining Our Westmoreland” campaign included public participation from more than 5,000 residents, community officials and business leaders. The outcome included multiple projects and core objectives that are aligned with specific strategies, incorporating over 300 different recommendations towards achieving those goals. Many goals reflect new initiatives that were approved over the last year by county commissioners, including additional money for tourism projects and the creation of a demolition fund to pay for the removal of blighted buildings throughout the county. The plan also identifies steps to improve job opportunities; highlights the county’s cultural, historical and recreation assets; seeks to revitalize urban centers and local business districts; promotes use of parks and nature; modernizes the local economy and enhances public transportation. These planning efforts are just part of many long-term growth initiatives that will dramatically help attract, develop and retain a diverse and stable workforce, which will ultimately sustain a healthy economy throughout Westmoreland County for many years to come.

The momentum and progress that is being gained to grow Westmoreland County economically could now be in jeopardy regarding the realignment or merging of districts. This also includes the potential loss of sufficient representation. Most importantly, any change within the status quo could ultimately increase the competitiveness of much needed funding resources at the state and

federal level, which is currently utilized for a variety of purposes, especially to supplement programs or projects such as Medicaid payments, education funding assistance, infrastructure assistance, and more. Some aid is awarded in the form of competitive grants, while other federal funding is given according to formulas established by law. Formula grants usually incorporate factors like population size, poverty statistics, and state matching dollars for distributing federal aid among counties. Competitive grants will also be at jeopardy since the vast majority of them are issued upon a discretionary basis and are more likely to fluctuate from year to year. Overall, any possibility of increasing our competition with surrounding counties due to redistricting or the loss of sufficient representation will not only slow progress, but could eventually stop the amount of growth that has been made to date.

On behalf of the Westmoreland County Chamber of Commerce, our Board of Directors, but most importantly our business community, we respectfully request the House State Government Committee, Mr. Mark Nordenberg and members of the redistricting panel take the time to review and understand the level of economic progress that has been gained throughout the past several years as well as our ongoing comprehensive plan that will continue to attract, develop, and retain a diverse and stable workforce in Westmoreland County. Most importantly, we respectfully request that our county, communities, and level of government representation remain as is. Especially, as we strive to enhance our economic footprint now and over the next several decades.

We will be happy to provide a copy of our "Reimagining Our Westmoreland" Comprehensive Plan to this committee or perhaps schedule time to review our progress and future plans in greater detail.

In closing, we want to thank members of this committee for your time and will be happy to answer any questions or provide additional information.